

CASE ID: 202010710002

EPISODE NAME: US Taiwan Arms Sales 2020

2020/10/27 - Ongoing

Sender: China (710)

Target: United States (2)

Issue: End Weapons/Materials Proliferation (9)

Final Outcome: Stalemate in the Threat Stage (4)

Narrative:

Following a series of Taiwan arms sales from the United States beginning 2020/10/21,¹ China threatened on 2020/10/27 that sanctions would be imposed on the U.S. officials responsible for the sale, as well as a series of US defense contractors: Lockheed Martin, Boeing Defense, Space & Security and Raytheon.² Sanctions would not have affected American defense contractors, though, as American firms have been barred from weapons sales to China since the Tiananmen Square massacre of 1989, though sanctions could affect their nonmilitary sales in China.³

China was provoked by the US's continued arms sales to Taiwan, starting on 2020/10/21 when the US sold Taiwan three weapons systems worth \$1.8 billion USD.⁴ Then on 2020/10/26, the US sold Taiwan \$2.37 billion USD worth of coastal defense systems.⁵ After China issued its 2020/10/27 threat, on 2020/11/03, the US sold Taiwan four aerial drones worth \$600 million USD followed by a Field Information Communications System worth \$280 million USD on 2020/12/07.⁶ In total, these sales by the US to Taiwan in 2020 amounted to \$5.1 billion USD worth of arms.⁷ There is no record of China formally responding to the 2020/11/03 or 2020/12/07 sales.

China did not impose the sanctions which they threatened to impose in response to these specific arms sales by the US.⁸ However, later arms sales did produce retaliation, and these sanctions are still in effect.⁹

¹ "Timeline: U.S. arms sales to Taiwan in 2020 total \$5 billion amid China tensions." *Reuters*, December 7th, 2020. [https://www.reuters.com/article/world/asia-pacific/timeline-us-arms-sales-to-taiwan-in-2020-total-5-billion-amid-china-tensions-idUSKBN28I0BF/#:~:text=Reuters%20Plus-,Timeline:%20U.S.%20arms%20sales%20to%20Taiwan%20in%202020%20total%20\\$5.1%20billion](https://www.reuters.com/article/world/asia-pacific/timeline-us-arms-sales-to-taiwan-in-2020-total-5-billion-amid-china-tensions-idUSKBN28I0BF/#:~:text=Reuters%20Plus-,Timeline:%20U.S.%20arms%20sales%20to%20Taiwan%20in%202020%20total%20$5.1%20billion).

² Davidson, Helen. "China sanctions major US defence companies after arms sales to Taiwan." *The Guardian*, October 27th, 2020. <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2020/oct/27/china-sanctions-major-us-defence-companies-after-arms-sales-to-taiwan>.

³ Johnson, Harold. "U.S. and European Union Arms Sales Since the 1989 Embargoes." *United States Government Accountability Office*, April 28th, 1998. <https://www.gao.gov/assets/t-nsiad-98-171.pdf>.

⁴ "Timeline: U.S. arms sales to Taiwan in 2020 total \$5 billion amid China tensions." *Reuters*, December 7th, 2020. [https://www.reuters.com/article/world/asia-pacific/timeline-us-arms-sales-to-taiwan-in-2020-total-5-billion-amid-china-tensions-idUSKBN28I0BF/#:~:text=Reuters%20Plus-,Timeline:%20U.S.%20arms%20sales%20to%20Taiwan%20in%202020%20total%20\\$5.1%20billion](https://www.reuters.com/article/world/asia-pacific/timeline-us-arms-sales-to-taiwan-in-2020-total-5-billion-amid-china-tensions-idUSKBN28I0BF/#:~:text=Reuters%20Plus-,Timeline:%20U.S.%20arms%20sales%20to%20Taiwan%20in%202020%20total%20$5.1%20billion).

⁵ Ibid.

⁶ Ibid.

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ Browne, Ryan. "Trump Administration Approves Arms Sale to Taiwan amid China Tensions." *CNN*, May 21st, 2020. <https://www.cnn.com/2020/05/21/politics/us-taiwan-arms-sale>.

⁹ "Decision on Taking Countermeasures Against U.S. Military Companies and Senior Executives." *The Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China*, 10 October 2024, www.mfa.gov.cn/mfa_eng/xw/wjbxw/202410/t20241011_11505419.html.